



FUEL WATCH

POLESTAR INSIGHTS

REPORTING PERIOD: 8 JULY 2026 - 14 JULY 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Fuel risk this week is mainly about cost and continuity rather than a single dramatic event. The pressure came from shortage and refinery disruption. Russia saw the most activity, with more reported from Ukraine and India. Operating pressure right now reads as high.

Cost indicators are holding above easy-budget levels, and the incident picture adds operational stress - shortages, forecourt disruption, subsidy moves and route pressure where they appear - rather than relief.

For business users, the headline is straightforward: protect fuel-dependent operations from short-notice price or availability shocks. That means live attention to fuel stock cover, generator runtime, road transport exposure and supplier resilience while this picture holds.

FAST FACTS

BRENT CRUDE

85.49 USD/bbl

+12.0% 7d

ICE Brent front-month (Yahoo Finance)

As of 16 Jul 2026

WTI CRUDE

80.20 USD/bbl

+11.3% 7d

NYMEX WTI front-month (Yahoo Finance)

As of 16 Jul 2026

JET FUEL

3.379 USD/gal

+19.5% 7d

U.S. Gulf Coast kerosene-type - EIA / FRED

As of 13 Jul 2026

JET FUEL PRICE TRAJECTORY

Jet fuel latest available 13 Jul 2026 (weekly EIA U.S. Gulf Coast series); Brent and WTI run to 16 Jul 2026 (the period end).

MARKET READ

Brent is sitting around 85.49 USD/bbl and WTI around 80.20 USD/bbl, which puts the crude complex in firm territory rather than a transient spike. The jet fuel series is rising over the period, with the latest figure at 3.379 USD/gal versus 2.828 at the start (+19.5%).

Taken together, this points to sustained cost pressure rather than a one-off move. Fuel-linked costs rarely stay isolated; they feed into freight rates, generator running costs, staff movement and supplier pricing - so treat these market indicators as the cost floor for the decisions that follow.

SITUATION

Fuel cost is holding above easy-budget levels while availability and policy pressure remain live downstream. This matters because cost pressure and availability pressure are showing up together right now, which is when contract economics and operational continuity stop being separate concerns. Russia is the country carrying the most weight.

WHAT HAPPENED

Reporting was led by shortage and refinery disruption concentrated on Russia, with secondary reporting from Ukraine and India. Operating pressure right now reads as high.

OPERATIONAL READ

The main themes right now are shortages, rationing and forecourt disruption; refinery disruption and supply-side outage. When forecourts dry up the constraint stops being price and becomes physical access; informal markets and queueing rules take over.

Watch for rationing rules, allocation cuts to commercial users and convoy or queue management announcements. Watch for restart timelines, force-majeure declarations and follow-on import announcements. Russia, Ukraine, India carry the most activity this week.

REGIONAL HIGHLIGHTS

Russia is the clearest pressure point right now. Recent activity points to shortages, rationing and forecourt disruption. The pressure here is on the export and sanctions side: crude and product flows, discounts and the buyers still willing to lift Russian barrels are what reset landed costs for dependent importers. Watch for sanctions-enforcement steps, price-cap changes, export-duty moves and any shift in the discount at which Russian crude and products clear.

Ukraine is a secondary but credible concern. Recent activity points to shortages, rationing and forecourt disruption. The pressure here is on physical supply and distribution: refinery and depot damage, import dependence and the logistics of keeping fuel moving are what determine availability on the ground. Watch for damage to refining and storage, import and rail-supply arrangements and any rationing or allocation measures for commercial users.

India adds further weight to the picture. Recent activity points to fuel-operational reporting. Pump-price moves, forecourt disruption and transport cost are where this lands first; local movement and distribution economics absorb the shock before the published headline catches up. Watch for state-level fuel-tax changes, fresh forecourt or rationing reports and any operator-side surcharge announcements on road and rail.

GULF AND HORMUZ CHOKEPOINT WATCH

The Strait of Hormuz and wider Gulf were this reporting period's dominant fuel-route risk, with a marked concentration of chokepoint reporting. Coverage centred on Hormuz closure and shipping disruption, forcing dependent crude and product flows onto longer, costlier routes and lifting the war-risk premium. Pressure peaked on 13 Jul 2026 with the period's most serious chokepoint incident: UAE says Iranian missiles struck oil tankers in Strait of Hormuz, one sailor killed.

Bypass pipelines and alternative routing featured as the main mitigation. The chokepoint remains a live, standing watch given the fragility of the route.

- 13 Jul 2026 - UAE says Iranian missiles struck oil tankers in Strait of Hormuz, one sailor killed - High
- 13 Jul 2026 - Iran's IRGC shoots down US drone over Strait of Hormuz, escalating tensions in world's most important oil chokepoint - High
- 12 Jul 2026 - Iran attack on vessels in Strait of Hormuz spikes oil prices 5% - High
- 11 Jul 2026 - IRGC missile strikes on commercial ships in Strait of Hormuz rattle oil markets and spotlight Iran's crypto sanctions playbook - High
- 11 Jul 2026 - Strait of Hormuz Attacks: Oil and LNG Tankers Turn Back Amid Renewed Hostilities - News and Statistics - High
- 10 Jul 2026 - US strikes Iran, revokes oil waiver after attacks on ships in Strait of Hormuz - High

Older chokepoint reporting from before this period, retained for context only - not current-period activity.

- 7 Jul 2026 - US ends Iran's brief oil opening after Hormuz tanker attacks - High
- 7 Jul 2026 - Iranian Attacks Hit Qatari LNG Tanker Near Strait of Hormuz, U.S. Revokes Oil License - High
- 7 Jul 2026 - Oil Climbs After Reported Iran Attack On Ships In Strait of Hormuz, Bringing Strait of Malacca into Focus - High

- 7 Jul 2026 - QatarEnergy chartered LNG carrier hit by projectile in Strait of Hormuz - High
- 7 Jul 2026 - Oil and gas prices rise after tanker hit by missile in Strait of Hormuz - High
- 7 Jul 2026 - Oil prices rise after report of Iranian attack on commercial ships in Strait of Hormuz - High

PRODUCER AND BUYER ACTIONS

ACTOR	CATEGORY	ACTION	OPERATIONAL READ
ADNOC	Producer action	Laden Adnoc L&S VLGC revealed as vessel fired at in Strait of Hormuz 8 Jul 2026	Supply-side move with read-through to bunker, jet and downstream pricing if the action sustains.
Infrastructure operator	Infrastructure / routing action	South Korea reroutes oil via Red Sea as Iran recloses Strait of Hormuz - CHOSUNBIZ 12 Jul 2026	Keeps Gulf and Red Sea routing diversification a live mitigation theme rather than a future option.
Market	Market / supply signal	How Ukraine's devastating drone attacks triggered Russia's fuel shortage crisis 8 Jul 2026	Supply resuming eases the local shortage; pump-price and surcharge pressure should soften as availability normalises.

WHAT MATTERS

Elevated crude and a jet fuel series that is not retreating tell the cost side of the story: fuel-linked invoices stay heavy. The incident picture then tells the availability side: shortages, rationing and route pressure are the points where price stops being the only problem and physical access becomes the issue. Exposure to Russia is the live pressure point for fleet, generator and field operations.

Where the two reinforce each other - high prices meeting tight supply or chokepoint disruption - the operational impact compounds. Freight rates lift, surcharge clauses fire, generator runtime decisions get made on tighter stocks, and supplier conversations turn into renegotiations rather than confirmations. That is the picture worth planning against now.

IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Revisit contract pricing on bulk fuel and surcharge pass-through clauses in freight and logistics agreements before the next billing cycle reprices them.
- Forward-cover the bulk and aviation fuel lines you depend on rather than waiting for the spot move to be confirmed.
- Check on-site fuel stock cover and generator runtime assumptions, and pull commercial-allocation conversations forward with suppliers.

- Agree escalation triggers in advance - queues, allocation cuts, station closures - so mitigations fire automatically rather than after the fact.

WATCH NEXT

- Subsidy or levy decisions - a single gazette notice can reset pump price and contract economics overnight.
- Rationing or forecourt disruption - queue formation, allocation cuts or station closures are the fastest operational tells.
- Refinery outages or force-majeure declarations - these feed into crack spreads and downstream pricing within days.
- Tanker and route disruption - fresh Gulf, Hormuz or Red Sea advisories, naval movement or vessel reroutes shift war-risk premium and transit time.
- Generator fuel availability - diesel and LPG stock cover at high-fuel-use sites is the continuity tell when forecourts tighten.

POLESTAR VIEW

Fuel Watch is flagging a cost-and-continuity risk right now, not simply a rise in fuel headlines. The market indicators show elevated fuel costs holding rather than easing, while the incident picture shows operational stress around shortages, route pressure and policy intervention. For business users, the priority is to protect movement, backup power and fuel-dependent operations from short-notice price or availability shocks. Russia is the clearest country pressure point, with the rest of the picture filled in by Ukraine and India.

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